encumbered by innumerable governmental tasks. Finally, everything is compounded by *time*. Everything had to be done almost at once, under the relentless pressure of contemporary technology. Dispatch was of the essence.

Taken together, these factors—above all, time—limit the number of men with whom the constitutional Commander in Chief can engage in meaningful consultation. To maximize the prospect of a wise and viable choice, some interests cannot be excluded. In the missile crisis the issue was pre-eminently a matter of *defense* and *diplomacy;* it depended throughout on the capability of our *intelligence* and posed the possibility of *military* action. As constituted, the Ex Comm assured representation of these interests. Natural parochialism, stemming from the governmental positions of these men, guaranteed that considerations of defense, diplomacy, intelligence, and military action would be voiced. But, potentially, the life of the nation was at stake. How was this interest represented? By the President himself, with aides of his own choosing, not least RFK.

Time made the presidential mind the only source available from which to draw politically legitimated judgments on what, broadly speaking, can be termed the political feasibilities of contemplated action vis-à-vis our world antagonists: judgments on where history was tending, what opponents could stand, what friends would take, what officials would enforce, what men in the street would tolerate—judgments on the balance of support, opposition, and indifference, at home and abroad.

Where was Congress? What about those other minds legitimated by election? They were out of play, except to have their leadership informed at the last moment. Earlier consultation offered nothing indispensable. Congress, to be sure, could add legitimacy, but of this the President conceived he had enough. As a nationally elective officer he was, himself, more representative than any single congressman or senator and no less representative than all of them together. Besides, command decisions rested constitutionally with his office, not theirs. So he decided first and told them after.

Precursors of those thirteen days were the four days, June 24–27, 1950, from the time the North Koreans crossed the border until we committed troops then occupying Japan. As Kennedy would do some twelve years later, President Truman called into almost continuous session the officials most concerned, foreshadowing the Ex Comm; with their advice he escalated step by step to match successive revelations of North Korean strength and South Korean weakness, sending in observers